

The Team Health Playbook

How to Diagnose, Fix, and Sustain
High-Performing Teams

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The Operating Leader

*“The best time to fix a team problem was three months
ago.
The second best time is today.”*

A Note Before We Start

I've spent twenty years building and leading teams. I built Mailigen from four people crammed into a 12-square-meter office to forty people and an acquisition in 2020. I served as VP Product at Pipedrive — a 700-person company navigating a private equity transition with Vista Equity Partners. Now I'm leading product transformation at a robotics startup, crossing the chasm from scrappy early-stage to disciplined scale.

Along the way, I've made every mistake in this playbook. I've watched teams go silent. I've seen talented people burn out on hamster wheels. I've lost great people because I wasn't paying attention.

This playbook is what I wish someone had handed me at each of those stages. It's not theory. It's the distilled, practical toolkit I use every single week. Every framework has been tested in real companies, with real teams, under real pressure.

Here's my promise: if you spend one hour reading this and one week implementing it, you'll understand your team better than most leaders do after years. And you'll have specific moves to make things better — starting tomorrow morning.

Let's get into it.

Part 1: The 5 Dimensions of Team Health

Why Most Leaders Get Team Health Wrong

Here's how most leaders think about team health: they wait until something breaks. Someone quits. A project fails. Two people stop speaking to each other. Then they react.

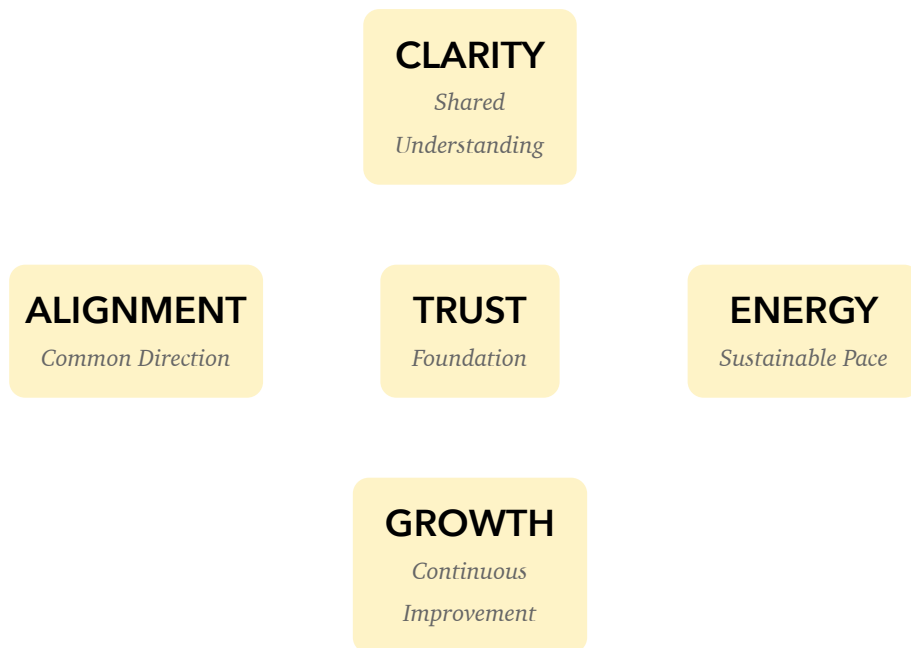
That's not leadership. That's firefighting.

The problem isn't that leaders don't care about their teams — most do, deeply. The problem is they don't have a framework for thinking about team health before things break. They rely on gut feel. And gut feel is unreliable, because by the time your gut tells you something's wrong, it's been wrong for months.

I learned this the hard way at Mailigen. We were fifteen people and things felt great — until suddenly they didn't. Two engineers quit in the same week. I was blindsided. But when I looked back honestly, the signals had been there for months. I just didn't have a system for seeing them.

That's why I developed the CETAG framework. Five dimensions. Every team problem I've ever encountered traces back to one or more of these five things. Once you see through this lens, you can't unsee it.

The CETAG Framework



These aren't abstract values to hang on a wall. They're diagnostic lenses. Think of them like vital signs for your team. A doctor doesn't wait for a patient to collapse before checking blood pressure. You shouldn't wait for a resignation letter before checking Clarity.

Let me break each one down.

Dimension 1: Clarity

The question: Does every person on this team know exactly what they should be doing, why it matters, and how success is measured?

Clarity is the most underrated dimension. Leaders think they've been clear because they said something once in an all-hands meeting. But saying something is not the same as being understood. And being understood is not the same as being internalized.

Here's my test: if I walk up to any person on my team and ask "What are the three most important things you're working on this quarter, and why do they matter?" — they should be able to answer without hesitation. If they pause, hedge, or give me a different answer than I would give, we have a Clarity problem.

What healthy Clarity looks like:

- People make decisions autonomously because they understand priorities
- New information gets filtered through shared context — people can self-organize
- Debates happen about how to do things, not what to do or why
- When plans change, people understand the reasoning quickly

What Clarity decay looks like:

- People ask permission for things they should decide themselves
- The same questions come up repeatedly in different meetings
- Work gets done that nobody asked for — “I thought this was the priority”
- People feel busy but can’t articulate impact
- There’s a gap between what leadership thinks the team is doing and what’s actually happening

The Clarity Cascade

Clarity breaks down in layers. At the top, the leader might have a clear vision. But it degrades at every level:

Level	Clarity Question	Common Failure
Mission	Why does this team exist?	Assumed, never stated explicitly
Strategy	How will we win?	Changes too often or not at all
Priorities	What’s most important right now?	Everything is “high priority”
Individual	What should I do today?	Guesswork based on incomplete info
Measurement	How do we know we’re winning?	No clear success metrics

One thing you can do today: Cancel one recurring meeting that doesn’t create obvious value. Just cancel it and see if anyone notices.

Dimension 2: Energy

The question: Does this team have the emotional and physical capacity to do great work?

Energy isn’t about working hours. I’ve seen teams work 60-hour weeks with incredible energy. I’ve seen teams work 35-hour weeks in a state of exhaustion. Energy is about the

ratio of fuel to friction. Fuel includes: meaningful work, progress, recognition, autonomy, connection to purpose, good relationships. Friction includes: unnecessary meetings, unclear processes, micromanaging, context switching, technical debt, bad tools, and — most dangerously — learned helplessness.

Technical debt has a twin: energy debt. Most teams don't die from lack of talent or bad strategy. They die from slow energy bleeds that accumulate. Every bad meeting adds to the energy debt. Every process that doesn't matter. When I walk into a new team, I don't check their velocity first. I check their energy. Because every feature shipped, every sprint completed — that's not work. That's the output of energy.

Energy is invisible and nonlinear. A team at 60% energy doesn't produce 60% of the work. They produce 20% of the work — and it's the wrong 20%. Because when energy is low, people stop taking risks, stop pushing back on bad ideas, stop caring about craft.

Your job as a leader isn't to be a cheerleader. It's to manage the kill side and maximize the right side of this equation. That means killing things. Protect meeting hygiene as fiercely as you'd protect code quality. Question every process. Kill dead initiatives. Make sure people see how their work connects to something that matters. It's full friction, not “motivate the things” that drain energy without creating value.

The Energy Equation

Make sure people can see how their work connects to something that matters. A brilliant engineer who connects the thing that they're building to things that matter is worth 10x more than one who thinks they're building yet another feature for its own sake.

Energy Source	Energy Drain	Net Effect
Clear purpose	Unclear priorities	Confusion tax
Autonomy	Micromanagement	Disengagement
Progress visibility	Work disappears	Why bother?
Good tools	Fighting the system	Friction fatigue
Recognition	Work unnoticed	Slow checkout

One thing you can do today: Ask three people: “What's one thing that's draining your energy that I could remove?” Then actually remove it.

Dimension 3: Trust

The question: Can people on this team be vulnerable with each other and know they won't be punished for it?

Trust isn't soft. It's the foundation that makes everything else possible. Without trust, Clarity doesn't matter — people won't believe what you say anyway. Energy doesn't matter — people will hoard it for self-protection. Alignment doesn't matter — people will nod in meetings then do their own thing. Growth doesn't matter — people won't risk failure.

I used to think trust was binary: you have it or you don't. But trust has layers:

1. Contractual trust: I believe you'll do what you explicitly committed to
2. Competence trust: I believe you have the skills to do your job
3. Care trust: I believe you have my back as a person
4. Vulnerability trust: I can show weakness without it being used against me

Most teams get stuck at level 2. They trust each other to be competent professionals. But real team performance requires levels 3 and 4. That's when people start telling you about problems early. That's when they push back on your bad ideas. That's when they take real risks.

The Trust Test

Here's how to know if you have real trust: Count how many times in the last week someone on your team:

- Admitted they didn't know something
- Asked for help publicly
- Challenged your idea directly
- Shared a personal struggle
- Owned a mistake without hedging

If the number is zero, you don't have a trust problem. You have a trust crisis.

One thing you can do today: In your next team meeting, admit something you don't know or share a mistake you made. Model vulnerability first.

Dimension 4: Alignment

The question: Is everyone rowing in the same direction, and do they know why that direction matters?

Alignment isn't agreement. I don't need everyone to agree with every decision. I need them to understand the decision, commit to it, and row in the same direction. The most aligned teams I've seen have fierce debates. But once the debate is over and the decision is made, they move as one.

Alignment breaks in predictable ways:

- Vertical breaks: Leadership decides one thing, middle management communicates another, individuals do a third
- Horizontal breaks: Team A optimizes for speed, Team B optimizes for quality, they ship broken features slowly
- Temporal breaks: This quarter's priority contradicts last quarter's, but nobody explicitly said we're changing direction

The hardest part about alignment is that it's not a one-time thing. You can't have an offsite, get aligned, and check it off your list. Alignment is like balance — you're constantly making small adjustments to maintain it.

The Alignment Stack

Level	Alignment Check
Company	Do we know what game we're playing?
Team	Do we know our part in winning that game?
Individual	Do I know how my work helps us win?
Tactical	Are our day-to-day actions consistent with our stated priorities?

One thing you can do today: Write down what you think your team's 1 priority is. Ask everyone else to do the same. Compare notes. Be shocked by the variance.

Dimension 5: Growth

The question: Is the team getting better over time, and does each person see a path to grow?

Growth is the most overlooked dimension because it's the least urgent. You can survive for months without it. But teams that aren't growing are dying — they just die slowly. The best people leave first. They're not leaving for money. They're leaving because they're bored.

Growth happens at three levels:

1. Individual growth: Each person is learning and advancing
2. Team growth: The team is getting better at working together
3. Impact growth: The team is taking on bigger, more important problems

Most leaders focus only on individual growth — career ladders, skill development, promotions. But team growth is what creates step-function improvements. A team that's 10% better at making decisions is more valuable than a team where everyone is 10% better at their individual jobs.

The Growth Formula

Growth = Challenge + Support + Reflection

- Challenge without support = burnout
- Support without challenge = stagnation
- Challenge + support without reflection = repeated mistakes

One thing you can do today: Ask someone on your team: "What's one skill you want to develop this quarter?" Then find a real project that forces them to develop it.

Part 2: The Daily Practice

Knowing the five dimensions is just the start. The real work is building a practice around them. Here's the system I use every week to keep a pulse on team health.

The Weekly Rhythm

Monday: Clarity Check (10 minutes)

- Review this week's priorities
- Ask yourself: "Would everyone on my team list the same top 3?"
- If unsure, send a quick Slack: "Quick check: what are your top 3 priorities this week?"

Tuesday: Energy Scan (15 minutes)

- Look at everyone's calendar
- Count meetings vs. deep work time
- Notice who's in back-to-back meetings all day
- Cancel at least one unnecessary meeting

Wednesday: Trust Builder (20 minutes)

- Have one genuine conversation that's not about tasks
- Share something you're struggling with
- Ask someone for their real opinion on something

Thursday: Alignment Audit (15 minutes)

- Sit in on another team's standup or planning session
- Notice: are they optimizing for the same things you are?
- Address any drift immediately

Friday: Growth Investment (30 minutes)

- Spend 30 minutes teaching someone something
- Or learning something from someone on your team
- Or reflecting on what the team learned this week

Total time: 90 minutes per week. Less than most people spend in a single bad meeting.

The Question Bank

Here are the exact questions I use. Pick 2-3 per week. Don't overwhelm people — this isn't an interrogation.

Clarity Questions

1. "If you had to explain our team's mission to a smart friend, what would you say?"
2. "What's one thing we're doing that you're not sure why we're doing it?"
3. "On a scale of 1-10, how clear are you on what success looks like for your current project?"
4. "What decision are you avoiding because you're not sure what the right answer is?"
5. "If our CEO asked you what our team's biggest bet is right now, what would you say?"

Energy Questions

6. "What's giving you energy at work right now? What's draining it?"
7. "If you could change one thing about how we work together, what would it be?"
8. "How much of your time feels like meaningful work vs. busy work?"
9. "What's one meeting you attend that you don't think you should?"
10. "When you close your laptop on Friday, do you feel energized or exhausted?"

Trust Questions

11. "What's one thing you've been wanting to bring up but haven't?"
12. "Is there anyone on the team you find it difficult to work with? Why?"
13. "Do you feel comfortable pushing back when you disagree with me?"
14. "When was the last time you asked someone on the team for help?"
15. "What's one piece of feedback for me that you've been holding back?"

Alignment Questions

16. "Do you understand how your work connects to company goals?"
17. "What's one project another team is doing that doesn't make sense to you?"
18. "If you were CEO for a day, what's one thing you'd change about our direction?"
19. "Are there any conflicts between what we say we value and how we actually operate?"
20. "What trade-offs do you think we're making as a team? Are they the right ones?"

Growth Questions

21. "What's one skill you want to develop but haven't had the chance to?"
22. "Who on the team do you learn the most from? What do you learn?"

23. “What’s the biggest challenge you’re facing right now? How can I help?”
24. “Looking back 6 months, what’s the biggest way you’ve grown?”
25. “What kind of problems do you wish you were solving?”

Red Flags: The Early Warning System

These are the subtle signals I’ve learned to watch for. Any one of them might mean nothing. Multiple signals in the same dimension means you need to act.

Clarity Red Flags

- People start sentences with “I thought we decided...” or “Didn’t we already...”
- The same topics keep coming up in retros
- New hires take longer than expected to become productive
- Increase in “quick sync” meetings to clarify things
- People build the wrong thing despite best intentions

Energy Red Flags

- Camera-off culture in remote meetings when cameras used to be on
- Slack response times steadily increasing
- People stop decorating desks or sharing personal updates
- Lunch breaks get shorter or longer (avoidance)
- Nobody volunteers for new projects
- Work quality becomes mechanical — no craft
- Phrases like “it is what it is” become common

Trust Red Flags

- Increase in “Reply All” emails and CCs
- Documentation becomes defensive rather than helpful
- Side conversations increase, public discussions decrease
- People preface opinions with excessive caveats
- New people get warned about certain topics
- Decisions get relitigated after meetings
- “Who” becomes the first question when something goes wrong

Alignment Red Flags

- Teams start optimizing metrics that conflict
- “That’s not my job” or “That’s their problem” becomes common
- Increase in escalations to leadership
- Projects get “thrown over the wall” between teams
- Public agreement but private criticism
- Strategy changes feel like whiplash rather than evolution

Growth Red Flags

- Your best people stop asking for new challenges
- Learning discussions disappear from 1:1s
- People stop sharing articles or ideas
- Retros become complaint sessions without improvement
- Senior people hoard knowledge instead of teaching
- “We’ve always done it this way” becomes a valid argument

Part 3: The Intervention Playbook

When you spot problems, here's exactly what to do. These aren't theoretical — I've run each of these interventions multiple times.

The Clarity Reset (2 hours)

When to use: When people can't articulate priorities or keep working on the wrong things.

The process:

1. Hour 1: Leadership team only. Write down:
 - Why does this team exist? (1 sentence)
 - What are we trying to achieve this quarter? (3 bullets max)
 - What are we explicitly NOT doing? (This is crucial)
 - How will we know if we succeeded? (Specific, measurable)
2. Hour 2: Full team session
 - Present the above (10 min)
 - Break into small groups: "What questions does this raise?" (20 min)
 - Address every question publicly (20 min)
 - Each person writes their personal priorities based on team priorities (10 min)

The key: The NOT doing list is as important as the doing list. Clarity is as much about what you won't do.

The Energy Audit (1 week)

When to use: When the team feels sluggish despite working hard.

The process:

Day 1-3: Data gathering

- Everyone tracks their time in 30-minute blocks
- Categories: Deep Work, Meetings, Admin, Firefighting, Waste
- Note energy level after each block (1-5)

Day 4: Analysis

- Aggregate the data
- Look for patterns: What correlates with low energy?

- Identify the top 3 energy drains

Day 5: Action

- Present findings to team
- Collectively decide what to stop/change/start
- Make the changes immediately — not “next quarter”

The key: You must actually kill things. If you do an energy audit and change nothing, you’ve made things worse.

The Trust Rebuild (4 weeks)

When to use: When people stop sharing real feedback or taking risks.

Week 1: Model vulnerability

- Share a real failure or uncertainty in a team setting
- Ask for help publicly on something
- Admit when you don’t know something

Week 2: Create safety

- In every meeting, explicitly ask for dissenting opinions
- When someone disagrees, thank them publicly
- Share the “Vegas Rule”: what’s said in the room stays in the room

Week 3: Address the elephant

- Run a “What are we pretending not to know?” session
- Write all responses anonymously
- Address each one without blame

Week 4: Institutionalize

- Create a weekly “failure forum” — celebrate learning from mistakes
- Start meetings with “what’s one thing that didn’t go well?”
- Recognize people publicly for productive disagreement

The key: Trust is built through repeated small actions, not grand gestures.

The Alignment Workshop (Half day)

When to use: When teams are working hard but pulling in different directions.

The agenda:

Part 1: The Game (1 hour)

- What game are we playing as a company?
- What does winning look like?
- What's our role in winning?

Part 2: The Tensions (1 hour)

- List all the tensions/tradeoffs we face
- For each: what's our default choice?
- Are these the right defaults?

Part 3: The Commitments (1 hour)

- What will we optimize for?
- What will we explicitly de-prioritize?
- How will we handle conflicts?

Part 4: The Contract (30 min)

- Write it all down
- Everyone signs it (literally)
- Post it where everyone can see it

The key: Alignment isn't about agreeing on everything. It's about agreeing on how to disagree.

The Growth Sprint (2 weeks)

When to use: When people feel stuck or bored.

Week 1: Discovery

- Each person identifies one skill they want to develop
- Find a real project that requires that skill
- Pair them with someone who has that skill

Week 2: Execution

- They own the project with support
- Daily check-ins on learning, not just progress
- End with a “teaching moment” — they teach others what they learned

The key: Growth happens through challenging projects with support, not training courses.

Part 4: The Maintenance System

The biggest mistake leaders make is treating team health as a problem to solve rather than a garden to tend. You don't "fix" team health once. You maintain it constantly.

The Monthly Health Check

First Friday of every month, score each dimension:

Dimension	Green (7-10)	Yellow (4-6)	Red (1-3)
Clarity	Everyone knows priorities	Some confusion	Nobody's aligned
Energy	People excited to work	Going through motions	Visible exhaustion
Trust	Open, honest dialogue	Some guardedness	Fear and politics
Alignment	Moving as one	Some drift	Active conflict
Growth	Everyone leveling up	Some stagnation	People checking out

Rules:

- Be honest — optimism won't fix problems
- Track trends — is it getting better or worse?
- Share scores with the team — transparency builds trust
- Focus on one dimension at a time — don't boil the ocean

The Quarterly Reset

Every quarter, run a half-day session:

Hour 1: Retrospective on health

- What improved? What degraded?
- What interventions worked?
- What did we learn?

Hour 2: Pick the focus

- Which dimension needs the most work?
- What's our specific goal?
- What are we willing to sacrifice?

Hour 3: Design the practice

- What will we do daily?

- What will we do weekly?
- How will we measure progress?

Hour 4: Make commitments

- Each person commits to one behavior change
- Write them down publicly
- Check in weekly

The Leadership Practice

Your personal practice as a leader:

Daily (5 minutes)

- Notice one thing about team health
- Send one message of recognition
- Have one real conversation

Weekly (30 minutes)

- Review your Health Check scores
- Pick 2-3 questions from the Question Bank
- Cancel one meeting that doesn't need to happen

Monthly (2 hours)

- Deep dive on one dimension
- Run a focused intervention
- Update your practices based on what you learn

Quarterly (4 hours)

- Run the full reset process
- Get anonymous feedback on your leadership
- Adjust your approach

Part 5: The Hard Truths

After twenty years of doing this, here are the uncomfortable truths I've learned:

Sometimes It's You

The hardest pill to swallow: sometimes you are the problem. Your team has low trust because you don't model vulnerability. They lack clarity because you change your mind without explaining why. They have low energy because you add friction through your need for control.

The question isn't whether you're contributing to problems — you are. The question is whether you're brave enough to see it and change it.

Signs the problem might be you:

- The same issues follow you from team to team
- People are different (worse) around you than with others
- Feedback to you is always vague and positive
- Your team's health scores are consistently lower than peer teams
- Good people leave and cite “growth opportunities” or “new challenges”

What to do:

1. Get a coach or trusted advisor
2. Ask for specific behavioral feedback
3. Pick one thing to change and stick with it for 30 days
4. Measure the impact on team health
5. Repeat

Sometimes Someone Has to Go

Not every person is fixable in every environment. Sometimes, despite your best efforts, someone is destroying team health. Maybe they're brilliant but toxic. Maybe they're kind but incompetent. Maybe they were great once but the job outgrew them.

Keeping the wrong person is not kind — it's selfish. You're avoiding a hard conversation at the expense of everyone else.

Signs someone needs to go:

- Other good people threaten to leave because of them
- Team health improves when they're absent
- You've given clear feedback and seen no change
- They consistently violate team values
- The team routes around them like broken infrastructure

How to do it well:

1. Document specific behaviors and impacts
2. Give clear, direct feedback with timelines
3. If no improvement, make the call quickly
4. Be generous in the transition
5. Learn from it — how did they get there?

Sometimes the Problem Is Structural

You can't fix a broken system with good intentions. Sometimes low team health is a symptom of deeper organizational issues:

- The company strategy changes every quarter
- Leadership doesn't model the values they preach
- The organization design creates inevitable conflict
- Resources are so constrained that success is impossible
- The business model requires unsustainable practices

In these cases, you have three choices:

1. Fix what you can control and shield your team from the rest
2. Escalate and push for systemic change
3. Leave and find a healthier environment

There's no shame in option 3. Life is too short to fight unwinnable battles.

The ROI Question

Executives always ask: "What's the ROI of team health?"

Here's my answer: What's the ROI of not having heart disease? It's not that health makes you rich — it's that disease makes everything else impossible.

But if you need numbers:

- Healthy teams ship 3x more with the same headcount
- Turnover drops by 50%+ (and hiring costs 50-150% of salary)
- Good people join because good people tell them to
- Decisions happen 10x faster when trust is high
- Innovation happens when people aren't afraid

The real question isn't "can you afford to invest in team health?" It's "can you afford not to?"

Part 6: Your 30-Day Quick Start

Don't try to do everything. Here's exactly what to do in your first 30 days:

Week 1: Diagnose

Monday: Score each dimension honestly (1-10)

Tuesday: Pick your weakest dimension to focus on

Wednesday: Have three conversations using questions from that dimension

Thursday: Identify the top 3 problems in that dimension

Friday: Share your findings with the team

Week 2: Design

Monday: Pick one intervention from Part 3

Tuesday: Adapt it to your specific context

Wednesday: Get buy-in from key people

Thursday: Schedule it

Friday: Prepare thoroughly

Week 3: Execute

Run your intervention

Don't overthink it. Don't make it perfect. Just run it and learn.

Week 4: Embed

Monday: Debrief — what worked, what didn't?

Tuesday: Pick one practice to continue weekly

Wednesday: Put it on everyone's calendar

Thursday: Do it

Friday: Celebrate the small wins

Your Day One Action

If you do nothing else after reading this playbook, do this:

Cancel your worst recurring meeting. You know the one — everyone dreads it, nothing gets decided, it should have been an email. Cancel it right now. Tell the team you're experimenting with fewer, better meetings.

That's it. You've started.

The Close

Building healthy teams isn't about being a perfect leader. I'm not. It's about paying attention, having a system, and caring enough to do something when you see problems.

The frameworks in this playbook aren't magic. They're just tools. What matters is that you use them. Consistently. Even when — especially when — things feel fine.

Because the best time to fix a team problem was three months ago. The second best time is today.

Now go cancel that meeting.

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